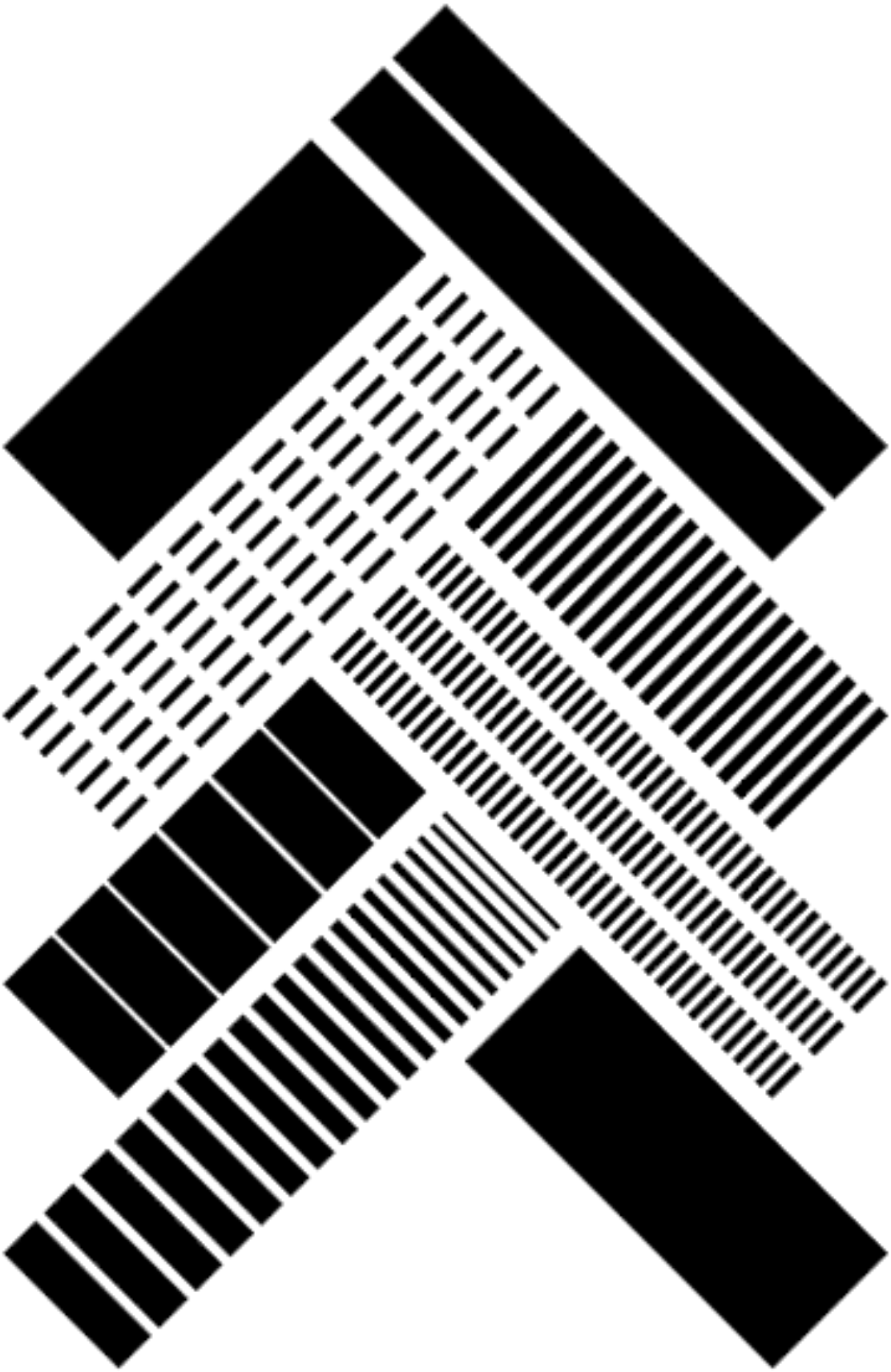


THEORY DISCIPLINE

For students taking units:

FGCT5006 Games Art Pathway (Games Art)

FGCT5012 Performance Animation (Games Animation)

FGCT5019 Games Studio (Games Design)

FGCT5017 Tools and Production (Games Development)

ASSESSMENT DUE: Friday 24 April 2026 by 5pm

SYNOPSIS

This discipline explores concepts and issues central to the historical, theoretical and aesthetic dimensions of the video game medium and the practice of play. It critically examines the position of video games and gamers within culture and society, exploring gaming's relationship to, conflict, art, ideology, and capital considering the expressive, social and political potential and limitations of the gaming medium.

Sessions will cover:

INTRODUCTION
PROCEDURAL RHETORIC AND SERIOUS GAMES
GAMES AS ART
NATURE IN GAMES
WAR GAMES
MONEY GAMES
MODULE SUMMARY AND ASSESSMENT

THEORY DISCIPLINE SYNOPSIS

UNIT LEARNING OBJECTIVES

FGCT5006 Games Arts Pathway

LO1 Demonstrate **knowledge** of critical and contextual connections to your portfolio submission, using academic conventions which apply critical knowledge, understanding and analysis of relevant examples (including your practice) to your chosen pathway.

FGCT5012 Performance Animation

LO1 Demonstrate **knowledge** of critical and contextual connections to your portfolio submission, using academic conventions which apply critical knowledge, understanding, and analysis of relevant examples (including your practice).

FGCT5019 Games Studio

L01: Demonstrate **knowledge** of critical and contextual connections to your portfolio submission, using academic conventions which apply critical knowledge, understanding, and analysis of relevant examples (including your practice).

FGCT5017 Tools and Production

LO1: Demonstrate **knowledge** of critical and contextual connections to your portfolio submission, using academic conventions which apply critical knowledge, understanding, and analysis of relevant examples (including your practice).

THEORY DISCIPLINE ASSESSMENT REQUIREMENTS

Table A1 - Assessment Components

Please note that this assessment contributes to your overall portfolio submission for the units listed on the front page of this document.

Assessment Component List all separate components	Typical Indicative Assessment tasks Where the component comprises more than one assessment task	Assessment Type For each component double click in the box to see options. The options equate to the assessment types in table A2	Word Count Approx word count where applicable
Portfolio	1,750-word essay demonstrating knowledge of critical and contextual connections to your portfolio submission, using academic conventions which apply critical knowledge, understanding, and analysis of relevant examples (including your practice).	Portfolio	1,750

DEADLINE

For students taking units:

FGCT5006 Games Arts Pathway
FGCT5012 Performance Animation
FGCT5017 Tools and Production
FGCT5019 Games Studio

1750-word Academic Essay Due 24/04/2026 by 5 pm via Turnitin

TIMETABLE

Please note: attendance at all taught sessions is compulsory, not optional. A register of attendance is kept: unexplained absences will be investigated, and appropriate action taken.

Video lectures, copies of lecture slides, the Unit Handbook, and your reading lists are available on myUCA.

SESSION DETAILS

INTRODUCTION
PROCEDURAL RHETORIC
GAMES AS ART
NATURE IN GAMES
WAR GAMES
MONEY GAMES
MODULE SUMMARY AND ASSESSMENT

SESSION 1: INTRODUCTION

DATE: 05/02/2026

This session will introduce you to the central focuses of part one of the unit wherein the complex relationship between the video game medium and key elements of our culture are explored and mapped.

We will also take the opportunity to discuss the unit's schedule, structure and assessment.

SESSION 2: PROCEDURAL RHETORIC

DATE: 12/02/2026

Ian Bogost's idea of 'procedural rhetoric', in which one can analyse and critique games mechanics as well as aesthetics from an ideologically infected position, altered the landscape of formal games criticism. It accompanied Bogost's endorsement of the short lived 'serious games' movement, and his subsequent criticisms of the idea of serious games, from which he has since distanced himself, provide a window into an important phase in recent gaming history.

We will explore how figures such as Bogost and phenomena like serious games and gamification have tried to harness the apparently inherent educational and rhetorical influence of the video game medium to change the world.

ESSENTIAL READING:

Bogost, Ian. (2007). *Persuasive Games: The Expressive Power of Videogames*. Cambridge: MIT Press. (pp. p.1 – 3, 20 – 21 & 29 – 34)

FURTHER READING:

Althusser, L. (1971). Ideology and Ideological State Apparatus (Notes Toward an Investigation). In: *Lenin and Philosophy and Other Essays.* Trans. Ben Brewster. London: Monthly Review Press.Available at: csun.edu/~snk1966/Lous%20Althusser%20Ideology%20and%20Ideological%20State%20Apparatuses.pdf

Bogost, Ian.(2006*). Unit operations: an approach to videogame criticism*, Cambridge, Mass. : MIT Press.

Breuer, J & Bente, G. (2010). Why so serious? On the relation of serious games and learning. [online] *Eludamos. Journal for Computer Game Culture*, 4(1). Available at: https://www.eludamos.org/index.php/eludamos/article/view/vol4no1-2/150

Charsky, D. (2010). *From Edutainment to Serious Games: A Change in the Use of Game Characteristics*. Games and Culture, 5(2), 177–198. https://doi.org/10.1177/1555412009354727

Deterding, S., Sicart, M., Nacke, L., O'Hara, K., Dixon, D. (2011). Gamification: Using game-design elements in non-gaming contexts. In CHI'11 extended abstracts on human factors in computing systems (pp. 2425–2428). New York, NY: ACM.

Ferdig, R. (2016). 'Education' In: *The Routledge Companion to Video Game Studies*, London: Routledge. (p.319).

Flanagan, M. (2013) *Critical Play: Radical Game Design*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press. (223-249).

Gee, J. P. (2009). Deep learning properties of good digital games: How far can they go? In: *Serious Games: Mechanisms and* Effects, Edited by Ritterfeld, U. New York, NY: Routledge (pp. 67-82).

Perrotta, C., Bailey, C., Ryder, J., Haggis-Burridge, M., & Persico, D. (2019). Games as (Not) Culture: A Critical Policy Analysis of the Economic Agenda of Horizon 2020. *Games and Culture*. https://doi.org/10.1177/1555412019853899

Rettberg, S. (2008). Corporate Ideology in World of Warcraft. In: Digital Culture, play and identity: A World of Warcraft Reader, Edited by Hilde Corneliussen and Jill Walker. Cambridge: MA, The MIT Press.

Siedel, J.(2015) The Game of Tinder Gamification of Online Dating in the 21st Century, *Medium.com* Available at: https://medium.com/@jane_seidel/the-game-of-tinder-3c3ad575623f

Silverstone, R. (1999). Rhetoric, Play, Performance: Revisiting a study of the making of a BBC Documentary. In *Television and Common Knowledge*. Edited by Gripsrud and Joslein. London: Routledge.

SESSION 3: GAMES AS ART

DATE: 19/02/2026

Historically games have found themselves placed firmly in cultural categories of kitsch and commodity by critics working in more established forms. Film critic and cultural colossus Roger Ebert famously declared “video games can never be art”, a claim met by much dissent from the games community. In the 9 years since this statement many titles, writers and developers have actively challenged this assertion, from rejecting the value of being ‘art’ at all, to actively pursuing artistic status. The label of ‘art games’ began to gain popularity at the start of the 2010’s, with titles such as Journey and Flower being hailed as breakthrough moments in the medium achieving its own cultural legitimacy.

Are games art? Which ones? Why? Does being ‘art’ change the identity of the game itself? Can a market-facing triple A title be art? Is this even a productive or worthwhile question?

ESSENTIAL READING:

Henry Jenkins (2007). 'Games, the New Lively Art' In: *The WOW Climax: Tracing the emotional impact of popular culture,* New York: NY, New York University Press (p.19 - 40)

FURTHER READING:

Benjamin, W. (1936). “Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction” in *Illuminations*. (1968). ed. Arendt and Benjamin. London: The Bodley Head. Available online at:
http://www.marxists.org/reference/subject/philosophy/works/ge/benjamin.htm

Bordeiu, P. (1984). *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*. Cambridge, MA: MITPress

Bogost, I. (2012). “The Art of Video Games: From Pac Man to Mass Effect”. American Journal of Play Fall 2012. [online] available at:
http://www.journalofplay.org/sites/www.journalofplay.org/files/pdf-articles/5-1-book-review-5.pdf.

Burden, M and Gouglas, S. (2012). “The Algorithmic Experience: Portal As Art”. *Game Studies* Volume 12, Issue 2. [online] available at:
http://gamestudies.org/1202/articles/the_algorithmic_experience

Carroll, Noel. (1992). "The Nature of Mass Art," *Philosophic Exchange*: Vol. 23 : No. 1 , Article 5. (p.6)
Available at: https://digitalcommons.brockport.edu/phil_ex/vol23/iss1/5

Davies, Stephen. (2012). 'Definitions of Art' In: *The Routledge Companion to Aesthetics*, Edited by Berys Gaut and Dominic McIver Lopes, London, Routledge. (p.213-220)

Devine TC, Presnell WA, Miller S. Games as Art and Kant's Moral Dilemma: What Can Ethical Theory Reveal About the Role of the Game Designer as Artist? *Games and Culture*. 2014;9(4):277-310. doi:10.1177/1555412014538812

Ebert, R. (2010). Video games can never be art | Roger Ebert's Journal | Roger Ebert. [online] Rogerebert.com. Available at: https://www.rogerebert.com/rogers-journal/video-games-can-never-be-art

Immanuel Kant. (1987). *The Critique of Judgement*. Trans. Werner S. Pluher. Indianapolis: IND, The Hacket Publishing Company

Graeme Kirkpatrick. (2011). *Aesthetic Theory and the Video Game*. Manchester: Manchester University Press

Tavinor, G. (2016) 'Art and Aesthetics' In: *The Routledge Companion to Video Game Studies*. Edited by Mark J. P. Wolf and Bernard Perron. First Edition. London: Routledge. (pp. 59 – 66).

SESSION 4: NATURE IN GAMES

DATE: 26/02/2026

When American transcendentalist and woodsman par excellence Henry Thoreau grew weary of urban life, he retreated to the American outback to find solace. Today, we might come home from a hard day and instead turn to the virtual wilderness of Tirisfal Glades or Hyrule Field instead. But the turn from the city toward 'nature' is a cultural construct, as indeed is our concept of nature, and both have changed with the digitalisation of city, country and our lifestyle. Looking back to the history of the pastoral fantasy and the emergence of the 'great outdoors', we will consider why gaming is so committed to a binary urban/wilderness dynamic, and what our current game landscapes can tell us about ourselves.

ESSENTIAL READING:

Alenda Y. Chang (2019). 'Introduction: Edge Effects' In: *Playing Nature: Ecology in Video Games*, Minneapolis:MN, Minnesota University Press.

FURTHER READING:

Dooghan, D. (2019). Digital Conquerors: Minecraft and the Apologetics of Neoliberalism. Games and Culture, 14(1), 67–86. https://doi.org/10.1177/1555412016655678

Ford, D. (2016). "eXplore, eXpand, eXploit, eXterminate": Affective Writing of Postcolonial History and Education in Civilization V. Gamestudies.org. [online]. Available at: http://gamestudies.org/1602/articles/ford

Hayden, Erik. 2012. Thoreau's Walden: The Video Game. *Time Magazine* [website]. Available at http://newsfeed.time.com/2012/04/30/thoreaus-walden-the-video-game/

Hayot, E. & Wesp, E. (2009). Toward a Critical Aesthetic of Virtual-World Geographies. *Game Studies* [website]. Available at http://gamestudies.org/0901/articles/hayot_wesp_space

Kirkpatrick, G. (2011). *Aesthetic Theory and the Video Game*, Manchester: Manchester University Press.

Longan, M. (2008). Playing with landscape: social process and spatial form in video games. *Aether: the journal of media geography* 11, pp. 23–40.

Martin, P. (2011). The Pastoral and the Sublime in Elder Scrolls IV: Oblivion *Gamestudies.org*. [online]. Available at: http://gamestudies.org/1103/articles/martin

Williams, Raymond. 1973. *The Country and the City*. Nottingham, Spokesman.
Williams, Raymond. (1980). Ideas of Nature in: *Problems in Materialism and Culture*, London, Verso (P.67-85).

SESSION 5: WAR GAMES

DATE: 05/03/2026

Predator drone pilots use adapted PlayStation controllers to pilot their vehicles. The US Military funds civilian game-engine development to improve simulated combat training. Video games were invented by scientists working on the atom bomb. The interplay between the military industrial complex and gaming is complex and important. As game designers & consumers, how do we come to terms with this moral quagmire?

ESSENTIAL READING:

Dyer-Witheford and de Peuter (2009). Banal War: Full Spectrum Warrior In: *Games of Empire: Global Capitalism and Videogames.* Minneapolis: Minnesota Press. (p.97-122)

FURTHER READING:

Baudrillard, J. (1995). *The Gulf War Did Not Take Place*. Sydney: Power Publications.

Crogan, P. (2011). *Gameplay Mode*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.

Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri (2004). Multitude: War and Democracy in the Age of Empire, New York: NY, Penguin

Huntemann, N and Thomas Payne, M, Eds (2010). *Joystick Soldiers: The Politics of Play in Military Video Games.* 1st edn. New York: Routledge

Tim Lenoir and Luke Caldwell (2018). 'Introduction: The Military-Entertainment Complex and the Contemporary War Imaginary' In: *The Military-Entertainment Complex*, Cambridge: MASS, The Harvard University Press (p.16 - 47)

Väliaho, P. (2014). *Biopolitical Screens: Image, Power, and the Neoliberal Brain*. London: MIT Press

Voorhees, G. Call, J. Whitlock, K. Eds. (2012). *Guns, grenades, and grunts*: first-person shooter games. London: Continuum.

SESSION 6: MONEY GAMES

DATE: 12/03/2026

Video games are entertainment products. They operate in a system of commodities and are subject to pressures of market and corporate interest. With the advent of Steam and digital distribution, the commodity relationship of games to their consumers has changed. The rise of microtransactions and free-to-play has shifted the emphasis of many game developers to capturing attention with psychological manipulation, then monetising the compulsive play which results.

How can we begin to map contemporary gaming's complex relationship to money, and what moral responsibilities might we have to face as developers in an industry increasingly using predatory and manipulative tactic to pursue financial success?

ESSENTIAL READING:

Evans, E. (2016). The economics of free: Freemium games, branding and the impatience economy. *Convergence*, 22(6) https://doi.org/10.1177/1354856514567052

FURTHER READING:

Ash, J. (2015). *The Interface Envelope: Gaming, Technology, Power*. London: Bloomsbury Academic.

Crogan P,. Kinsley S. (2012). Paying attention: Towards a critique of the attention economy. *Culture Machine* [online] 13. Available at: http://culturemachine.net/index.php/cm/article/download/463/500.

Neely, E. L. (2019). Come for the Game, Stay for the Cash Grab: The Ethics of Loot Boxes, Microtransactions, and Freemium Games. Games and Culture. https://doi.org/10.1177/1555412019887658

Lehdonvirta and Castronova. (2014). *Virtual Economies: Design and Analysis*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press. p. 192- 196

Lin, H., & Sun, C.-T. (2011). Cash Trade in Free-to-Play Online Games. *Games and Culture*, 6(3), 270–287. https://doi.org/10.1177/1555412010364981

Marx, K (1897). *Capital Volume 1*[online version] accessible at: https://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1867-c1/ch01.htm#S4

[redacted]

SESSION 7: MODULE SUMMARY AND ASSESSMENT

DATE: 19/03/2026

READINGS

ESSENTIAL

Benjamin, W. (2008) [1936] *The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction*. London: Penguin.

Bogost, Ian. (2007) *Persuasive Games: The Expressive Power of Videogames.* London: MIT Press.

Cassell & Jenkins. (2000) *From Barbie to Mortal Kombat: Gender and Computer Games.* Cambridge: MIT Press.

Corneliussen & Rettberg. (2011) *Digital Culture and Play: A World of Warcraft Reader*. London: MIT Press.

Donovan, Tristan. (2010) *Replay: A History of Videogames*. Lewes: Yellow Ant.

De Puy & Dyer-Witherford. (2009) *Games of Empire: Global Capitalism and Video Games.* Minneapolis: University of Minneapolis Press.

Salen & Zimmerman. (2006) *The Game Design Reader: A Rules of Play Anthology*. London: MIT Press.

RECOMMENDED

Adorno, Theodor. (2001) [1944] *The Culture Industry: Selected Essays on Mass Culture*. London: Routledge Classics.

Baudrillard, Jean. (1995) *The Gulf War Did Not Take Place.* Sydney: Power Publications.

Bogost, Ian. (2011) *How to Do Things With Videogames*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.

Bolter & Gruin. (2000). *Remediation: Understanding New Media.* London: MIT Press.

Hjorth, Larissa. (2011) *Games and Gaming: An Introduction to New Media*. Oxford: Berg.

Juul, Jesper. (2013) *The Art of Failure: An Essay on the Pain of Playing Video Games*. Cambridge MA: MIT Press.

Juul,Jesper. (2012) *A Casual Revolution: Reinventing Videogames and their Players.* Cambridge: MIT Press.

Juul, Jesper. (2011) *Half-Real: Video Games between Real Rules and Fictional Worlds*. Cambridge MA: MIT Press.

Keogh, Brendan. (2013) *Killing is Harmless: A Critical Reading of Spec Ops: The Line.* Stolen Projects.

Lehdonvirta & Castronova. (2014) *Virtual Economies: Design and Analysis*. Cambridge: MIT Press.

Nelson & Shiff. (2003) *Critical Terms for Art History.* Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

McLuhan, Marshall. (1964) *Understanding Media.* London and New York: Routledge.

McGonigal, Jane. (2012) *Reality is Broken: Why Games Make Us Better and How They Can Change the World.* New York: Penguin.

Murray, Janet. (1997) *Hamlet on the Holodeck: the Future of Narrative in Cyberspace*. New York: The Free Press.

Perron & Wolf. (2003) *The Video Game Theory Reader*. London: Routledge.

Salen & Zimmerman. (2003) *Rules of Play: Game Design Fundamentals*. London: MIT Press.

Huntemann, Nina B. (2009). Joystick Soldiers. Routledge, 1st edition

ONLINE RESOURCES AND JOURNALS

Games and Culture: http://gac.sagepub.com/

Games Studies: http://gamestudies.org/

Journal of Digital Humanities: http://journalofdigitalhumanities.org/

Leonardo Electronic Almanac: http://www.leoalmanac.org/

Todigra Journal: http://todigra.org/index.php/todigra

TERM 2 SUBMISSION REQUIREMENTS

DEADLINE: 24th April 2026, 5 pm, through Turnitin

TASK DETAILS:

1,750-word essay demonstrating knowledge of critical and contextual connections to your portfolio submission, using academic conventions which apply critical knowledge, understanding, and analysis of relevant examples, including your practice.

Question: What recent games, media and franchises have informed the development of your practical portfolio? How might these points of inspiration be critically explored and contextualized using academic knowledge and insights into your creative practice. You might want to consider such issues as:

PROCEDURAL RHETORIC
GAMES AS ART
NATURE IN GAMES
WAR GAMES
MONEY GAMES

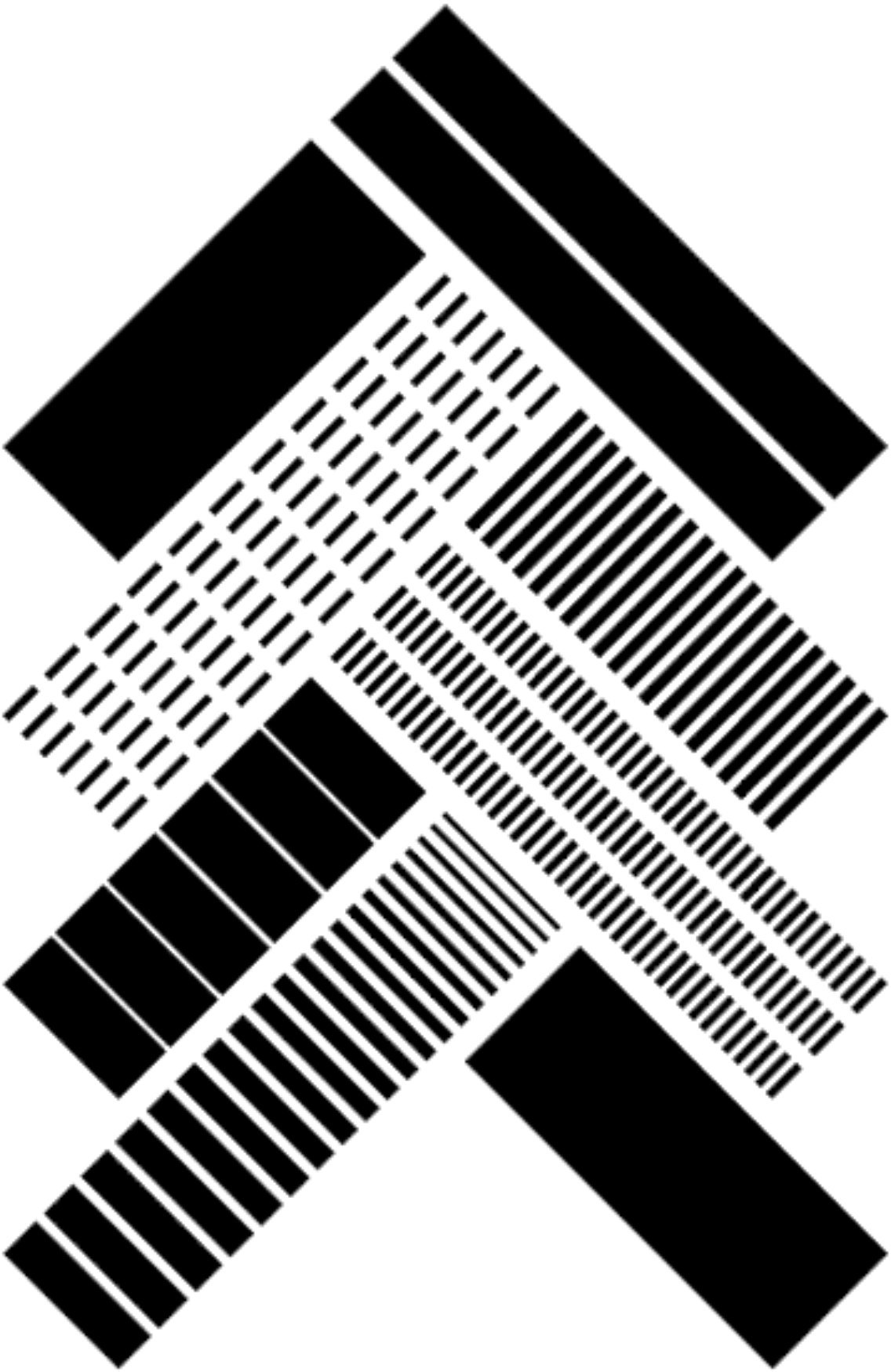
Your essay must include:

1. Reference to your creative project
2. A clear historical or critical framework
3. Discussion of at least three appropriate academic sources
4. A bibliography including only material you have explicitly referenced
5. A 200-word section detailing your research process

LO1 Demonstrate knowledge of critical and contextual connections to your portfolio submission, using academic conventions which apply critical knowledge, understanding and analysis of relevant examples (including your practice) to your chosen pathway.

Essay Notes

Academic essays are about engaging with scholarly research, analysing game examples through key concepts and debates, and developing a critical argument. You do not need to find a 'right' answer, or to exhaust all possible answers, but rather put forward a strong argument backed by research, analysis and academic skills.

You will need to include academic sources from appropriate publications. Use the library and the recommended reading for the sessions related to your subject as a starting point.

When using Turnitin, don't click submit and walk away: make sure you have confirmed submission, and if in doubt, contact me at my UCA email with a copy and an explanation of any technical issues.